Done-For-You Books

Sample Pack

Real pages from two finished books,
how the process works,
and what each package includes

Nicholas Dailey

Inside this pack

1. **How it works:** the six steps from your ideas to finished files.
2. ***A Soft Answer*** (31-day devotional): title page, contents, and one complete day, *Day 6: A Gentle Answer*.
3. ***Proverbs for the Public Square*** (6-week small-group study): title page, contents, one complete group session, *Session 4: Work That Serves*, and that session's leader notes.
4. **What you get:** the packages, author website add-on, and terms.
5. **Next steps:** the intake questionnaire.

Both sample books are my own, not client projects. Written with the assistance of AI writing tools, under the author's direction.

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Drafting uses AI writing tools under human direction. Every book then goes through an editing pass and fact-checking before delivery. You supply the ideas, outline, and voice through the intake questionnaire, and you review and approve every revision.

Each finished book carries a plain disclosure on its copyright page: *"Written with the assistance of AI writing tools, under the author's direction."*

About the samples

The pages that follow are taken unchanged from the print-ready 6x9 paperback interiors of two of my own books, with their original page numbers. Your book gets the same typesetting, layout, and quality check.

A Soft Answer

31 Days in Proverbs on Words, Disagreement, and Peacemaking in a Divided Age

Nicholas Dailey

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Day 6

A Gentle Answer

Wrath needs fuel. A gentle answer refuses to supply it.

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[1] *A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger.* [4] *A soothing tongue is a tree of life, but a perverse tongue crushes the spirit.*

Proverbs 15:1, 4 (BSB)

Mentor and Student

Student I may have just made my job a lot harder.

Mentor What happened?

Student We missed a big outbound shipment on Monday. Not my crew's fault, mostly. But Ray, one of the other shift leads, came onto the floor and started laying into me in front of everybody. Loud. Pointing. Saying my guys are lazy and I don't manage anything.

Mentor And you answered.

Student I answered. I said if he spent half as much time on his own dock as he spends complaining about mine, we'd hit every truck. Some of my guys laughed. Ray went straight to the operations manager.

Mentor How did it feel in the moment?

Student Amazing. For ten seconds.

Mentor Notice that's the second time you've said something like that this month.

Student I noticed.

Mentor Proverbs 15:1. "A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger." What did your answer do to Ray's anger?

Student Turned it into a formal complaint.

Mentor So it stirred. That's the word. Like stirring coals. Ray brought the fire. You brought the poker.

Student But what was I supposed to do? Let him tear into me in front of my crew? A gentle answer just means I roll over.

Mentor No. That's the mistake almost everyone makes about this verse. Gentle isn't the same as agreeing, and it isn't the same as silent. A gentle answer can say no. It can even say hard things. It just says them in a way that doesn't hand the other man more fuel. What could you have said that was gentle and still honest?

Student I don't know. "Ray, you're out of line"?

Mentor Closer. Try this. "You're right, we missed that truck, and I want to fix it. I'm not going to do this in front of the crew. Let's go to the office." What did that give up?

Student Nothing, really. It admits the truck was missed, which it was.

Mentor It gave up the chance to score. That's all. And look what it kept: your dignity, your crew's dignity, the truth, and a door for the conversation to continue somewhere better.

Student It doesn't feel as good.

Mentor Not for ten seconds. Look at verse 4, though. "A soothing tongue is a tree of life, but a perverse tongue crushes the spirit." Your crew watched that exchange. What did they learn about how a leader talks?

Student That you hit back harder.

Mentor And next time one of them gets yelled at by a driver, what will he do?

Student Okay. I get it. What do I do now?

Mentor Now you go find Ray before the operations manager calls you in. And you give him a gentle answer, a few days late.

Reflection

Few verses in Proverbs are as widely known as this one, and few are as widely ignored in practice. "A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger." It describes something everyone has watched happen: anger answered with anger grows, and anger answered with calm tends to shrink. We know this. We do the opposite anyway, because in the moment the harsh word feels like self-respect.

The verb in the second half is worth slowing down for. A harsh word *stirs up* anger. Anger, in this picture, is already present, like coals at the bottom of a fire. A harsh reply does not create it from nothing. It rakes it up, exposes it to air, and makes it burn hotter. The man who brings a harsh word to an angry conversation is not just defending himself. He is tending the fire.

A gentle answer works differently. It does not deny that the other person is angry, and it does not necessarily agree with him. It simply refuses to add fuel. That refusal is often enough. Anger is hard to sustain when it meets no resistance. Shouting at someone who answers quietly starts to feel strange, even to the person shouting.

The most common misunderstanding of this verse is that gentleness means giving in. It does not. Consider the answer the Mentor suggested: admit the missed truck, promise to fix it, and move the conversation off the floor and into the office. That answer contains a refusal. It sets a boundary. It even changes the terms of the conversation. But it does so without contempt, without escalation, and without handing the angry man a fresh grievance. You can be gentle and firm in the same sentence. Jesus described Himself as "gentle and humble in heart" (Matthew 11:29), and no one who reads the Gospels would call Him weak or vague.

A gentle answer usually has three parts:

1. **Lower the temperature.** Lower your volume and slow your pace. If the other person is standing over you, sit down or step back. Your body is part of your answer.
2. **Acknowledge what is true.** Almost every angry complaint contains at least a sliver of truth. The truck was late. The meeting did run long. Naming that sliver tells the other person you are not simply defending yourself, and it takes away the need for him to keep shouting it.
3. **Open a door.** Offer a next step: a better time, a better place, a question, an invitation. "Can we talk after the meeting?" "What would help most right now?" A gentle answer does not slam the conversation shut. It moves it somewhere it can go better.

Verse 4 widens the circle. "A soothing tongue is a tree of life, but a perverse tongue crushes the spirit." The words we use in conflict do not land

only on our opponent. Other people are always listening: children in the next room, coworkers on the dock, readers scrolling past a thread. A soothing tongue becomes a tree of life for them, a picture of how disagreement can be survived. A perverse tongue crushes the spirit, and not just the target's. Everyone who watches learns that this is how people talk when they are upset.

One more thing. Proverbs describes how life *generally* works. It is not a guarantee. Some people will stay angry no matter how gently you answer, and a few will read your gentleness as weakness and push harder. Later in this book we will look at what Proverbs says about those situations. But do not use the exceptions to excuse yourself from the rule. Most of the time, with most people, a gentle answer turns away wrath. You have probably seen it work. You may have seen it work on you.

Before You Speak

Lower, acknowledge, open. The next time someone comes at you angry, whether in person, by email, or in a comment, try the three-part answer before you say anything else. Lower: take a breath and lower your voice. Acknowledge: name one thing in their complaint that is true. Open: offer a next step or a question. If you already gave a harsh answer to someone this week, go back to that person and try the gentle one now. A late soft answer is better than none.

Prayer *Lord Jesus, You are gentle and humble in heart, and You were never weak. Give me a gentle answer when my pride wants a sharp one. Let my words be a tree of life to everyone listening. Amen.*

Journal

1. Describe a recent moment when you answered anger with anger. What were you protecting?
2. Whose gentle answer has turned away your own wrath? What did they say or do?
3. Who is watching how you handle conflict: children, coworkers, friends? What are they learning?

Proverbs
for the Public Square

A 6-Week Small-Group Bible Study
(with Leader's Guide)

Nicholas Dailey

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Session 4

Work That Serves

Diligence, laziness, craft, and the dignity of ordinary labor.

◊

Session at a Glance

Big idea. Proverbs honors work as a way of serving God and neighbor. Diligence builds households and communities; neglect slowly tears them down. Talk is cheap. Faithful labor is not.

Goal. By the end of this session, each person should be able to describe how his own daily work serves other people, identify one area of neglect, and identify one area where he needs rest rather than more work.

Scripture. Proverbs 24:30–34; 14:23; 12:11; 18:9. Also Genesis 2:15 and Colossians 3:23.

Memory verse. "There is profit in all labor, but mere talk leads only to poverty." (Proverbs 14:23)

Time. About 90 minutes. See the Leader's Guide for a 60-minute plan.

Open

Report back: *Who did you seek counsel from this week, and what did you hear?*

Then go around: *What was your first paying job? What did it teach you about work?*

Read the Scripture

> [30] *I went past the field of a slacker and by the vineyard of a man lacking judgment.* [31] *Thorns had grown up everywhere, thistles had covered the ground, and the stone wall was broken down.* [32] *I observed and took it to heart; I looked and received instruction:* [33] *A little sleep, a little slumber, a little folding of the hands to rest,* [34] *and poverty will come upon you like a robber, and need like a bandit.*
>
> Proverbs 24:30–34 (BSB)

> *There is profit in all labor, but mere talk leads only to poverty.*
>
> Proverbs 14:23 (BSB)

> *The one who works his land will have plenty of food, but whoever chases fantasies lacks judgment.*
>
> Proverbs 12:11 (BSB)

> *Whoever is slothful in his work is brother to him who destroys.*
>
> Proverbs 18:9 (BSB)

The first passage is one of the few places in Proverbs where the writer tells a story from his own life. He walks past a neglected field, stops, looks, and learns. Read it slowly. The rest are single verses that each make one sharp point.

Mentor and Student

Early on a Saturday. The Mentor finds the Student in the parking lot of the motel on Route 9, measuring the shoulder of the road with a wheel.

Mentor You're up early.

Student The listening session was good. Really good, actually. Forty people came. Mr. Pruitt and the other neighbors behind the motel had two complaints I'd never heard: the kids would be walking to the bus stop on the shoulder of a 45-mile-an-hour road, and the

drainage ditch along there floods every spring. Nobody on the board knew that.

Mentor So now you know.

Student So now I'm out here measuring. If we're going to ask the county for a sidewalk as a condition, I want to know how much room there is. I've got a guy who can price it.

Mentor That's how you serve a town. Somebody walks out to the ditch with a measuring wheel. Most people would rather post about the ditch.

Student There's been a lot of posting. You know what's funny? Half the board has opinions about this project, and I'm the only one who's read the staff report all the way through.

Mentor Chapter fourteen has a verse for that. Labor brings profit; mere talk brings poverty. Public life is full of talk. Meetings, posts, speeches, opinions. Some talk is necessary. But talk isn't work. The town gets better when somebody reads the report, measures the ditch, prices the sidewalk, and shows up on Saturday.

Student Speaking of work, I've got my own problem. I've got a guy on my crew, Danny. Good kid, but lately he's been disappearing. Takes forty minutes to get gas. Leaves edges half done. The other guys are covering for him and they're getting resentful.

Mentor Proverbs has a word for that too. "Whoever is slothful in his work is brother to him who destroys." Laziness isn't neutral. It wrecks things, just slower than a wrecking ball. And it wrecks the crew, not just the lawn.

Student So I fire him?

Mentor Did I say that? Have you talked to him?

Student I've yelled at him.

Mentor That's not talking. Something changed. Find out what. Maybe he's lazy. Maybe his mom's sick. Maybe he's working a second job at night. Maybe he's using. You owe him a straight conversation

before you owe him a pink slip. And then you owe your crew a fair answer either way.

Student That's fair.

Mentor Now let me ask you something. When's the last time you took a Saturday off?

Student I'm off right now. This isn't work. This is the board.

Mentor You're measuring a ditch at seven in the morning on a Saturday for a volunteer job, after a sixty-hour week. When did you last see your daughter's whole softball game?

Student ...I'm the coach. I'm there.

Mentor Are you? Or are you on your phone in the dugout answering texts about the motel?

Student You're not going to let me feel good about anything today, are you?

Mentor You should feel good about the ditch. You should also remember that the same God who sent the slacker to watch the ant gave you a Sabbath. Diligence isn't the same as never stopping. A man can serve his town and lose his family doing it. I've seen it. I almost did it.

Teaching

Work before the curse

The Bible's view of work begins before sin enters the world. "The LORD God took the man and placed him in the Garden of Eden to cultivate and keep it" (Genesis 2:15). Work was part of paradise. The curse after the fall made work painful and frustrating, but it did not make work bad. Cultivating, keeping, building, fixing, serving: these are part of what it means to be human and to bear God's image.

Proverbs assumes this throughout. It honors the farmer, the craftsman, the merchant, the shepherd, and the household manager. It mocks the sluggard. It treats diligent work as wisdom and laziness as folly. And because work

always involves other people, customers, employers, coworkers, neighbors, it is one of the main ways we live out wisdom in public.

The slacker's field

Proverbs 24:30–34 is a little parable. The writer walks past a field and a vineyard that belong to "a slacker" and "a man lacking judgment." Notice what he sees: thorns everywhere, thistles covering the ground, and "the stone wall was broken down" (Proverbs 24:31).

There is no single disaster here. No fire, no flood, no thief. Just slow neglect. The thorns grew a little each week. The wall lost one stone, then another. The owner was probably not wicked. He was just always going to get to it.

Then the writer does something we rarely do: "I observed and took it to heart; I looked and received instruction" (Proverbs 24:32). He doesn't just criticize the neighbor. He learns from what he sees. The lesson is the little refrain about sleep and folded hands, and the warning that poverty comes "like a robber," suddenly, though it was building for a long time.

The broken wall is worth noticing. In the ancient world, a stone wall protected a field from animals and thieves. When it fell, the damage didn't stay on one man's land. Neglect has public consequences. The house with the collapsing roof affects the whole street. The board member who doesn't read the packet affects every resident. The inspector who signs without inspecting affects everyone who uses the building.

Talk versus labor

Proverbs 14:23, this week's memory verse, sets labor against "mere talk." This may be the most useful verse in Proverbs for anyone involved in public life. Meetings, debates, posts, and opinions all have their place, but they are not the same as getting something done.

Many communities are rich in talk and poor in labor. Everyone has a view about the park, the school, the church budget, or the homeless camp. Fewer people pick up trash at the park, tutor at the school, count the offering, or serve meals. The Christian who wants to bless his town should be suspicious of how much he talks about it compared with how much he works for it.

Working your land

"The one who works his land will have plenty of food, but whoever chases fantasies lacks judgment" (Proverbs 12:11). The contrast is between faithful attention to what is in front of you and chasing schemes elsewhere. Some people neglect their actual responsibilities, their families, jobs, and local commitments, while pursuing grand ideas, quick money, or causes far away.

Public life has its own fantasies: the belief that one election, one law, one viral post, or one leader will fix everything. Meanwhile the land in front of us goes unworked: the neighbor who needs help, the kid who needs a mentor, the local board that needs a volunteer. Proverbs keeps calling us back to the field we have actually been given.

Sloth as destruction

"Whoever is slothful in his work is brother to him who destroys" (Proverbs 18:9). We usually think of destruction as active: vandalism, violence, fraud. Proverbs says the lazy man is a close relative of the destroyer. Both leave things worse than they found them. One does it fast; the other does it slowly.

This is a hard word for anyone who holds a position of trust. A public employee who does not do the job, a contractor who cuts corners where no one will see, a volunteer who signs up and doesn't show, a manager who ignores problems: each one destroys something, even if no one ever sees it happen.

Working as for the Lord

Paul gives the deepest reason for good work: "Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, as for the Lord and not for men" (Colossians 3:23). Our ultimate employer is Christ. That dignifies every honest job: mowing lawns, stocking shelves, driving trucks, teaching third grade, processing permits. It also raises the standard. If the Lord is watching, the edges matter even when the customer won't check them.

Paul also gives a public reason. The thief should stop stealing and "work, doing good with his own hands, that he may have something to share with the one in need" (Ephesians 4:28). Work supports us, and it is also how we

gain the means to help others. A community full of people who work hard and share generously is a strong community.

A word about rest and about those who cannot work

Two cautions keep this teaching balanced.

First, **diligence is not workaholism.** The same Bible that praises the ant also commands a Sabbath. Many people in public life, pastors, business owners, volunteers, officials, burn out because they never stop. Rest is not laziness. It is trust that God runs the world and you do not. If your work for the town is costing you your marriage, your children, or your health, something is out of order.

Second, **Proverbs' criticism of the sluggard is not a weapon to use against the poor.** The sluggard in Proverbs could work and won't. Many people cannot work, or cannot find work, or work hard and still cannot make ends meet. Proverbs is equally clear that God defends the poor and judges those who oppress them, as we will see in Session 6. It is easy to use "If anyone is unwilling to work, he shall not eat" (2 Thessalonians 3:10) as a slogan in public arguments. Notice the word *unwilling*. Paul was correcting able-bodied church members who had stopped working, not passing judgment on everyone in need.

Going Deeper: Nehemiah and the Wall

The book of Nehemiah is a case study in work that serves a community. Jerusalem's walls had lain in ruins for generations, a lot like the broken stone wall in the slacker's field. Nehemiah, a servant in the Persian court, heard the news, wept, prayed, and asked the king for permission to go and rebuild.

When he arrived, he did not begin with a speech. He inspected the walls himself, at night. Then he gathered the leaders: "You see the trouble we are in. Jerusalem lies in ruins, and its gates have been burned down. Come, let us rebuild the wall of Jerusalem" (Nehemiah 2:17). The

people answered, "Let us start rebuilding," and "they set their hands to this good work" (Nehemiah 2:18).

Nehemiah 3 is a long list of names and the sections of wall each family repaired, often the part nearest their own homes. Goldsmiths, perfumers, priests, rulers, and daughters all worked. It is one of the Bible's great pictures of a whole community doing ordinary labor together. Despite opposition, ridicule, and threats, "we rebuilt the wall until all of it was joined together up to half its height, for the people had a mind to work" (Nehemiah 4:6).

Nehemiah also refused to use his office for personal gain. He did not take the governor's food allowance, and "Instead, I devoted myself to the construction of the wall, and all my servants were gathered there for the work; we did not acquire any land" (Nehemiah 5:16). He worked alongside the people instead of over them.

The wall was finished in fifty-two days. Not because of one hero, but because many people each put back their own stones.

- What "section of the wall" in your community is nearest to you? Who else might work on it with you?
- What does Nehemiah's refusal to profit from his position say to people in public roles today?

Notes

Session 4 · Work That Serves

Discussion Questions

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Observe

1. In 24:30–31, list everything the writer saw in the slacker's field. Was there any single disaster?
2. What did the writer do after he saw it (24:32)?
3. According to 14:23 and 12:11, what leads to profit or plenty, and what leads to poverty or lack of judgment?

Interpret

4. Why do you think Proverbs compares sudden poverty to a robber (24:34), when the neglect was gradual?
5. The stone wall protected more than one field. What are some "stone walls" in your community that are crumbling through neglect?
6. In what sense is a slothful worker "brother to him who destroys" (18:9)?
7. How does "as for the Lord and not for men" (Colossians 3:23) change the meaning of an ordinary job?

Apply

8. Describe how your daily work, paid or unpaid, serves other people. Be specific.
9. Is there an area of your life, at home, at work, or in your community, where thorns are slowly growing? What is the first stone you could put back?
10. Where are you more like the talker than the laborer? And where do you need to rest rather than work harder?

Case Study

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The Volunteer Board. You serve on the board of a small community food pantry. For two years, the same four volunteers have done almost all the work: picking up donations, stocking shelves, and staffing the Saturday distribution. Meanwhile, the board meets monthly and spends most of its time debating policies, discussing a new logo, and planning a fundraiser that keeps getting postponed. Two of the four core volunteers have told you privately that they are exhausted and thinking of quitting. One board member suggests sending a strongly worded email to the congregation about "people who talk but never show up."

- How does Proverbs 14:23 apply to this situation? To whom?
- What is the difference between necessary talk and "mere talk" for a volunteer board?
- How would you respond to the suggestion of a strongly worded email?
- What practical steps could the board take to share the work and protect the exhausted volunteers?

Take-Home Practice

One stone in the wall. Choose one place of neglect this week. It might be at home (the repair you've been putting off), at work (the task you keep avoiding), or in your community (the cleanup, the visit, the meeting packet you never read). Do one concrete piece of work on it. Not the whole wall. One stone.

Then do the opposite somewhere else: pick one block of time this week and protect it for rest or for your family. Turn off your phone. Be fully present.

Next week, report on both: the stone you replaced and the rest you took.

Leader Notes

Session 4: Work That Serves

Goal for the leader

Help the group honor ordinary work as service to God and neighbor, recognize the slow damage of neglect, and also guard against overwork and against using "laziness" as a weapon against the poor.

Before the meeting

- Think about the range of work represented in your group: paid jobs, homemaking, retirement, unemployment, disability. Be sensitive to anyone without work or unable to work.
- Be ready to share your own first job story.

Notes on the discussion questions

Q1. Thorns, thistles, and a broken stone wall. No single disaster; only slow neglect.

Q2. He observed, took it to heart, and learned. Point out that he didn't just criticize the slacker; he applied the lesson to himself.

Q4. Neglect accumulates invisibly, but its consequences arrive suddenly, like a robber. The roof leaks for years, then collapses. The relationship erodes for years, then ends.

Q5. Possible answers: aging infrastructure, volunteer organizations kept alive by a few tired people, neighborhoods where no one knows each other, churches with no young leaders, civic groups with no new members. Ask: what is one stone you could replace?

Q6. Both the destroyer and the slacker leave things worse than they found them. One is fast and visible; the other is slow and hidden. The result is the same.

Q7. If Christ is the real employer, every honest job has dignity and every job deserves our best, even when no one else is checking.

Q10. Make room for both halves of this question. Some people need to hear "work harder." Others need to hear "rest."

Case study notes

The volunteer board case shows how "mere talk" can exist even in good organizations. Help the group see that the strongly worded email would probably be more talk, and might wound the people it's meant to motivate. Better steps: listen to the exhausted volunteers, have board members take shifts themselves, simplify the meetings, recruit specifically and personally, and thank the four who have carried the load.

Watch for

- Comments that equate poverty with laziness. Gently point to the "word about rest and about those who cannot work" section and to Session 6.
- People who are unemployed or underemployed. Make sure the session honors them and doesn't add shame.
- People who are overworked and proud of it. The Mentor's challenge about Saturday and the softball game is for them.

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Questions

Email **daileyReese227@gmail.com**, or see the full service page:
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AI disclosure

Written with the assistance of AI writing tools, under the author's direction. This applies to the sample books in this pack and to every book I produce. Drafting uses AI writing tools under human direction, followed by an editing pass and fact-checking before delivery.

Nicholas Dailey